

Relief, not jubilation: What India's Asia Cup win really means

India clinched the Asia Cup and **sealed its World Cup berth**, but the victory felt more like relief than triumph. A closer look at what the win says about Indian hockey and the state of the game in Asia.

Saikat Chakraborty

saikat.chakraborty@thehindu.co.in

The Indian men's hockey team arrived at the Asia Cup 2025 with one clear goal: to secure its berth at the 2026 World Cup. By the end of the tournament, it not only punched its ticket to Belgium and the Netherlands but also reclaimed its throne as Asia's best, winning the continental crown after an eight-year wait.

Seven matches in 10 sweltering

days in Rajgir tested Craig Fulton's men, but after a slow start they hit stride when it mattered most. The victory brings relief as much as joy, coming on the heels of a disastrous European leg of the Pro League 2024-25, where India lost seven straight matches.

For a team widely regarded as Asia's benchmark, this was less a breakthrough than a necessary restoration of aura.

With an average of more than 5.5

goals per game, India sparked in what Fulton had called the "most important tournament of the year."

It all began under the scorching August sun on Major Dhyan Chand's birth anniversary, celebrated as National Sports Day.

The heat was so fierce that volunteers carried buckets of water to the turf during quarter breaks, stretching them from two minutes to four.

Players shed up to three

